SILKEN TOUCH

SHE PROBABLY IS CUT FROM SILK, her strokes all languid grace and pleasing to the eye. Like her idol Sachin Tendulkar, Smriti Mandhana started her India journey young, debuting for the country before she turned 17. Ever since, the girl from Maharashtra's turmeric city Sangli has been India's go-to champion.

In the summer of 2013, when her peers were anxious about academic results, Smriti was dealing with an even bigger test. Just 16 and playing for the Indian team, she had been thrown in into the deep end with little room for mistakes. But she passed with flying colours. Four years later, in 2017, the modish left-hander was opening for India in the ODI World Cup in England. To many, her soothing elegance at the crease is reminiscent of another India opener, former men's team captain Sourav Ganguly. In the same Cup, she got her maiden ODI ton at Taunton—incidentally, the same venue where Ganguly scored a most celebrated hundred in the 1999 World Cup. "(*Laughs*) I can't recollect when I first heard those comparisons. I started getting that (comparison with Ganguly) once I started playing age-group cricket," recounts Smriti.

The 2017 World Cup had announced the arrival of Indian cricket's next poster girl and the team's campaign, where they finished No. 2 in the tournament, changed the landscape of women's cricket in India.

For Smriti, cricket runs in her blood. Her father was a cricketer, and so was her brother, who played a pivotal role in her taking up the game. "I took up the sport because of my brother. I started playing cricket with him. My father has also been a pillar of strength for me, both in the personal sphere and in my cricketing journey," says the southpaw bat.

Smriti fetched the biggest purse of Rs 3.4 crore at the auction of the inaugural season of the Women's Premier League, where she leads the Royal Challengers Bangalore. The bidding war to get Smriti on the roster was something unseen in women's cricket. "I want to credit the BCCI for the way they have supported women's cricket in the country," she says.

Smriti's success isn't restricted to one format. She raced to five ODI centuries in just 67 innings and is the fastest Indian (woman) to reach 3,000 runs in the format. Next year will be another big test for the Women in Blue with the T20 World Cup scheduled in Bangladesh. It will be an opportunity for Smriti and the team to take it a step further, win the Cup for the country. ■

-Rahul Rawat



GETTY IMAGES

Smriti Mandhana, *27*
Vice-captain, Indian women's cricket team

ACCOMPLISHMENT

Mandhana was the costliest pick at the Women's IPL auction and the opener's batting has seen comparisons with former men's team captain Sourav Ganguly

GAME PLAN

"Don't worry about the results. Follow the process, keep working hard and smart, and enjoy the game"

ROLE MODEL

Outside cricket, tennis legend Serena Williams